

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1974-07-29

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

149.1 We have received your letter of 19 June 1974 describing the preoccupation of some American believers with the date of the Lesser Peace, and with their feeling that "the calamity," as a prelude to that peace, is imminent.

149.2 It is true that 'Abdu'l-Bahá made statements linking the establishment of the unity of nations to the twentieth century. For example: "The fifth candle is the unity of nations—a unity which, in this century, will be securely established, causing all the peoples of the world to regard themselves as citizens of one common fatherland." And, in *The Promised Day is Come*, following a similar statement quoted from *Some Answered Questions*, Shoghi Effendi makes this comment: "This is the stage which the world is now approaching, the stage of world unity, which, as 'Abdu'l-Bahá assures us, will, in this century, be securely established." 149.3 There is also this statement from a letter written in 1946 to an individual believer on behalf of the beloved Guardian by his secretary:

All we know is that the Lesser and the Most Great Peace will come—their exact dates we do not know. The same is true as regards the possibility of a future war; we cannot state dogmatically it will or will not take place—all we know is that mankind must suffer and be punished sufficiently to make it turn to God.

149.4 It is apparent that the disintegration of the old order is accelerating, but the friends should not permit this inevitable process to deter them from giving their undivided attention to the tasks lying immediately before them. Let them take heart from the reassuring words of Shoghi Effendi contained in the closing paragraphs of his momentous message of 5 June 1947, and concentrate on the challenging tasks of this hour.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

219150 Passing of Laura Dreyfus-Barney, Compiler of *Some Answered Questions*

22 AUGUST 1974

To the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of France

150.1 ASCENSION DISTINGUISHED MAIDSERVANT LAURA DREYFUS-BARNEY
FURTHER

DEPLETES SMALL BAND PROMOTERS FAITH HEROIC AGE. MEMBER FIRST
HISTORIC

GROUP PARIS TAUGHT BY MAY MAXWELL SHE ACHIEVED IMMORTAL FAME
THROUGH

COMPILATION SOME ANSWERED QUESTIONS UNIQUE ENTIRE FIELD RELIGIOUS
HISTORY. OFFERING ARDENT PRAYERS SACRED THRESHOLD PROGRESS HER SOUL

ABHÁ KINGDOM URGE ALL COMMUNITIES FRANCE HOLD MEMORIAL
GATHERINGS

GRATITUDE OUTSTANDING ACHIEVEMENT.

UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

151 Comments on the Bahá'í Attitude Toward Material Suffering

19 NOVEMBER 1974

The National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of Italy Dear Bahá'í Friends, 151.1 In your letter of 11 September you say that the questions of how to help the Third World or the poor who are suffering under calamities are much discussed in your community and you wish to know whether to create a special fund for such needs, to ask for special contributions from time to time, or whether there are other ways in which you could help.

151.2 It is understandable that Bahá'ís who witness the miserable conditions under which so many human beings have to live, or who hear of a sudden disaster that has struck a certain area of the world, are moved to do something practical to ameliorate those conditions and to help their suffering fellow-mortals.

151.3 There are many ways in which help can be rendered. Every Bahá'í has the duty to acquire a trade or profession through which he will earn that wherewith he can support himself and his family; in the choice of such work he can seek those activities which are of benefit to his fellowmen and not merely those which promote his personal interests, still less those whose effects are actually harmful.

151.4 There are also the situations in which an individual Bahá'í or a Spiritual Assembly is confronted with an urgent need which neither justice nor compassion could allow to go unheeded and unhelpt. How many are the stories told of 'Abdu'l-Bahá in such situations, when He would even take off a garment He was wearing and give it to a shivering man in rags. 220151.5 But in our concern for such immediate obvious calls upon our succor we must not allow ourselves to forget the continuing, appalling burden of suffering under which millions of human beings are always groaning—a burden which they have borne for century upon century and which it is the mission of Bahá'u'lláh to lift at last. The principal cause of this suffering, which one can witness wherever one turns, is the corruption of human morals and the prevalence of prejudice, suspicion, hatred, untrustworthiness, selfishness and tyranny among men. It is not merely material well-being that people need. What they desperately need is to know how to live their lives—they need to know who they are, to what purpose they exist, and how they should act towards one another; and, once they know the answers to these questions they need to be helped to gradually apply these answers to everyday behavior. It is to the solution of this basic problem of mankind that the greater part of all our energy and resources should be directed. There are mighty agencies in this world, governments, foundations, institutions of many kinds with tremendous financial resources which are working to improve the material lot of human beings. Anything we Bahá'ís could add to such resources in the way of special funds or contributions would be a negligible drop in the ocean. However, alone among men we have the divinely given remedy for the real ills of mankind; no one else is doing or can do this most important work, and if we divert our energy and our funds into fields in which others are already doing more than we can hope to do, we shall be delaying the diffusion of the Divine Message which is the most important task of all.

151.6 Because of such an attitude, and also because of our refusal to become involved in politics, Bahá'ís are often accused of holding aloof from the “real problems” of their

fellowmen. But when we hear this accusation let us not forget that those who make it are usually idealistic materialists to whom material good is the only “real” good, whereas we know that the working of the material world is merely a reflection of spiritual conditions and until the spiritual conditions can be changed there can be no lasting change for the better in material affairs. 151.7 We should also remember that most people have no clear concept of the sort of world they wish to build, nor how to go about building it. Even those who are concerned to improve conditions are therefore reduced to combating every apparent evil that takes their attention. Willingness to fight against evils, whether in the form of conditions or embodied in evil men, has thus become for most people the touchstone by which they judge a person's moral worth. Bahá'ís, on the other hand, know the goal they are working towards and know what they must do, step by step, to attain it. Their whole energy is directed towards the building of the good, a good which has such a positive strength that in the face of it the multitude of evils—which are in essence negative—will fade away and be no more. To enter into the quixotic tournament of demolishing one by one the evils in the world is, to a Bahá'í, a vain waste of time and effort. His whole life is directed towards proclaiming the Message of Bahá'u'lláh, reviving the spiritual life of his fellowmen, uniting them in a divinely created World Order, and then, as the Order grows in strength and influence, he will see the power of that Message transforming the whole human society and progressively solving the problems and removing the injustices which have so long bedeviled the world.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

221152 Release of a Compilation on Opposition

26 NOVEMBER 1974

To all National Spiritual Assemblies Dear Bahá'í Friends, 152.1 Five months before he passed away, the beloved Guardian in his cable to the Bahá'í world, dated 4 June 1957, drew our attention to the fact that from both without and within the Faith evidences of “increasing hostility” and “persistent machinations” were apparent, and that they foreshadowed the “dire contest” predicted by ‘Abdu'l-Bahá, which was destined to “range [the] army [of] light [against the] forces [of] darkness, both secular [and] religious.” 152.2 The marvellous victories won in the name of Bahá'u'lláh, since those words were written; and the triumphs increasingly being achieved by His dedicated and ardent lovers in every land, will no doubt serve to rouse the internal and external enemies of the Faith to fresh attempts to attack the Faith and dampen the enthusiasm of its supporters, as evidenced by the book attacking Shoghi Effendi recently published in Germany by Hermann Zimmer, a Covenant-breaker, and the new book misrepresenting the Faith written by William Miller, a longtime enemy of the Faith who used to be a missionary in Persia.

152.3 We felt, therefore, that we could contribute to your devoted and incessant efforts to protect our precious Cause by placing in your hands a compilation from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh, of ‘Abdu'l-Bahá and of Shoghi Effendi, clearly outlining the principle that the progressive unfoldment and onward march of the Faith of God are bound to raise up adversaries, indubitably foreshadowing the worldwide opposition which is to come, and unequivocally giving the assurance of ultimate victory. This compilation is far from complete and exhaustive, but provides a basis for the study of this all-important subject.

152.4 We leave it to your discretion, in consultation with a Hand or Hands of the Cause who may be available, as well as with the Counselors, to decide in what manner, and how much of this material should be shared with the friends. In some areas it may be best for National

Spiritual Assemblies to publish these extracts in Bahá'í newsletters gradually, in others the circulation or even publication of the entire compilation, with other pertinent texts, if called for, may be desirable; in yet other areas it may be enough to draw the attention of the friends to this important subject, through courses and lectures based on these texts and given in conferences and summer schools.

152.5 We feel strongly that, whatever method is chosen to inform the friends, the time has come for them to clearly grasp the inevitability of the critical contests which lie ahead, give you their full, support in repelling with confidence and determination "the darts" which will be leveled against them by "their present enemies, as well as those whom Providence will, through His mysterious dispensations, raise up, from within or from without," and aid and enable the Faith of God to scale loftier heights, win more signal triumphs, and traverse more vital stages in its predestined course to complete victory and worldwide ascendancy.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

222153 Formation of Five New National Spiritual Assemblies during Rí ǵvǻn 1975 and Readjustment of the Zones of African Continental Boards of Counselors

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]